

The Closed Door Is Not a Suggestion

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Essay

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A mildly exasperated defense of closed doors, private snacks, and the lost art of asking first.

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There is a particular sound a teenage boy makes when he is trying not to be heard.

It is not silence. Silence would be too obvious and, frankly, beyond the technical abilities of most teenage boys. It is more like a sequence of small disasters performed with confidence. A doorknob turns. A hinge sighs. A foot hits a laundry basket or some mysterious object that has lived in the hallway since 2017. Then comes the pause. The kind of pause that says, “If I don’t move for three seconds, maybe physics will forget I exist.”

And then, from my office downstairs, I hear a guitar.

Not a guitar being carefully removed from its stand by its lawful owner. Not a guitar being picked up after permission has been granted and a small ceremonial transfer of responsibility has occurred. No. This is my oldest son, whose bedroom is in the basement on the same level as my office, deciding at whatever hour of the night that my office is apparently a branch location of Guitar Center with looser security.

He is eighteen now, which means he is technically an adult, at least according to the law and his own internal press releases. But he has been doing this for years. I will go downstairs the next morning and notice that something is not quite right. A guitar has migrated. A knob on the stereo has been turned. A cable is where no cable should be. One of my things has clearly been used, adjusted, handled, explored, or otherwise subjected to the private research program of a teenage male.

Nobody asked. Nobody mentioned it. The office doesn't have a door as we haven't installed it yet, but in most civilized societies, a parent's workspace means something. But in my house, apparently, an invisible door with an implied bit of privacy is less boundary than decorative suggestion.

To be fair, I love that my kid plays music. I do. I would rather hear a guitar being played than hear him getting into something genuinely stupid, illegal, or involving the phrase “watch this” or “hold my beer.” There are worse problems than having a son who wants to pick up an instrument. At the end of the day, if the great family crisis is that a kid is interested in guitars, we are not exactly living in a Greek tragedy.

Still.

When did it become acceptable for children to just walk into a parent’s office or bedroom and help themselves to whatever they want? When did the parental domain become public property? When did “it’s in the house” become the legal standard for “I may now touch it, eat it, wear it, move it, break it, or leave it somewhere weird”?

Because this is not limited to guitars.

Two of my other sons have developed a separate but equally bold operation involving snacks. My wife and I, foolish optimists that we are, sometimes store certain snacks in our bedroom because if we leave them in the kitchen, they disappear with the speed and violence of a natural disaster. You buy a box of something on Tuesday, and by Wednesday morning the box is empty except for one torn wrapper and a spiritual sense of betrayal.

So we put a few things in our room. Not because we are hoarding luxury goods. Not because we are eating imported chocolates from a velvet-lined drawer while the children gnaw on bark in the kitchen. We are simply

trying to make something last more than one day. A modest dream. The American dream, really, if that now includes keeping crackers alive until Thursday.

But the boys know. They always know.

The door can be shut. The house can be quiet. I can be at work in my basement office, answering emails, solving problems, pretending I know the answers to everyone's software issues, and somewhere upstairs a boy is entering my bedroom like he is part of an elite snack recovery unit.

No hesitation. No moral struggle. No trembling hand on the doorknob as he reflects, "This is my parents' private room."

None of that. He just goes in.

And if confronted, the defense is always somewhere in the neighborhood of, "Well, it was in the house."

That, right there, may be the most spiritually exhausting sentence in modern parenting.

"It was in the house."

As if the house is a communist village and all Pop-Tarts must be redistributed according to need, appetite, and who got there first. As if ownership dissolves at the front door. As if a parent's bedroom is not a bedroom, but a lightly restricted warehouse with pillows.

I do not remember living this way as a kid.

I can probably count on one hand the number of times I went into my parents' bedroom when I was young, and even then it was with permission. Their room was not a casual space. It was not part of the general tour. You did not just wander in, flop on the bed, open a drawer, borrow something, and stroll back out like you were checking inventory.

There were lines.

Not perfect lines. Not always clearly explained lines. But lines. My parents' room was one of them. Adults had spaces. Adults had things. And you did not need a dissertation on boundaries to understand that some doors were not for you.

Part of it was respect. Part of it was fear.

Let's be honest. Fear did some work. We can pretend otherwise now because we are all enlightened and emotionally aware and trying not to become the people who shouted at us for breathing too loudly near the good furniture. But fear was absolutely in the mix. Not terror. Not abuse. Just the healthy childhood awareness that if you crossed certain lines, consequences would arrive swiftly and without a lot of discussion about your inner journey.

You did not go rummaging around in your parents' room because you valued your life, your weekend, and your ability to sit comfortably.

I am not saying that was all good. I am not romanticizing the old days like every father before 1997 was a wise village elder. A lot of families confused obedience with respect.

So, to be fair, maybe some of this change is good. Kids today are more comfortable talking to their parents. They expect explanations instead of “because I said so,” and honestly, sometimes they deserve them. I want my boys to feel safe in their own house. I want them to know they belong here.

But there is a difference between feeling safe and feeling entitled to every square inch of the house. That is where things get muddy.

Somewhere along the line, a lot of kids seem to have confused closeness with access. They live in the house, so they assume the house is theirs in the fullest possible sense. The food is theirs. The tools are theirs. The chargers are theirs. The blankets are theirs. The room with the closed door is theirs if they are hungry enough.

Kids get away with one thing or another; a parent can't catch every small thing. That is, until the small things become the house rules.

That is the part nobody tells you about parenting. A family culture is built by all the little moments you let pass because you are tired, busy, distracted, or just trying to get through Tuesday without turning dinner into a courtroom proceeding.

The kids learn from what happens. They also learn from what does not happen.

If they walk into your room and take snacks and nothing really changes, they learn something. If they use your guitar without asking and the only consequence is a tired sigh the next morning, they learn something.

They learn that boundaries are negotiable if nobody wants to enforce them.

And honestly, who wants to enforce them all the time? Parenting already comes with enough unpaid security work. You monitor screen time, schoolwork, chores, tone of voice, whether somebody actually brushed their teeth or just stood near the sink with water running in a suspicious little performance.

It gets old.

But the bigger issue is not the guitar. It is not the stereo. It is not even the snacks, although I will admit the snacks feel personal. The bigger issue is whether children understand that other people, even their parents, are allowed to have private space, private belongings, and small areas of life that are not instantly available to them.

That matters.

A parent is not just a service provider with car keys. A parent is not just a wallet, kitchen staff, tech support, and emergency search party for the missing shoe that is somehow always directly under the bed. A parent is a person. A full person. A person with things they care about, places where they think, hobbies that belong to them, snacks they were hoping to eat later, and a bedroom that should not require a lock.

That may sound obvious, but I am not sure it is obvious anymore.

We have raised kids in a world where access is instant. Music is instant. Movies are instant. Food can arrive at the door because somebody tapped a rectangle. Answers appear before the question has fully formed. Everything is available.

So maybe it should not surprise us when the same mindset shows up inside the house. The song is there, so play it. The video is there, so watch it. The snack is there, so eat it. The guitar is there, so use it. The room is there, so enter it.

Right now, we live in a culture that has made wanting something feel a lot like having a right to it. That is dangerous training for a kid, because life will not work that way for long. Roommates will not appreciate it. Spouses will not appreciate it. Employers will not appreciate it. Friends will not appreciate it. At some point, the world will say, “That is not yours,” and it is better to learn that lesson at home over a bag of chips than later over something that actually hurts somebody.

Because boundaries are not just about control. They are about respect.

They teach a child that other people have limits. Other people get tired. Other people may say no. Other people may own a guitar that is not a community guitar, even if it looks very tempting under the basement lights at midnight, regardless who bought it.

And this is where the humor starts to fade a little, because under all the ridiculousness is something I care about a hell of a lot. I do not want my boys to obey me because they are afraid of me. I do not want them tiptoeing around the house like Victorian orphans worried about displeasing Father. I am not trying to build a home where everyone needs a written request to touch a granola bar.

But I do want them to understand that love does not erase respect.

Being family does not mean everything is yours. Being comfortable does not mean you stop asking. Being hungry does not mean the closed bedroom door loses all meaning. Being curious does not mean you get to handle someone else’s things whenever the mood strikes.

That is not cruelty. That is basic decency.

And maybe that is the strange challenge of modern parenting. We are trying to raise kids who are not scared of us, while also raising kids who do not treat us like vending machines with opinions. We want openness without chaos. Warmth without entitlement. Trust without our office becoming a midnight music lab.

It is a tough balance.

Sometimes I miss the old clarity, even if I do not want the old fear. I miss the simple understanding that a parent’s room was different. A closed door meant stop. Someone else’s things were not yours unless they said so. You did not need a lecture series. You just knew.

Maybe every generation of parents has its version of this complaint. Maybe my parents wondered why we left bikes in the driveway, drank all the milk, and acted like lights turned themselves off through divine intervention. Maybe their parents thought they were raising savages because somebody touched the thermostat. Maybe the first cave parent looked at a child dragging a stick through the sleeping area and thought, “This generation has no respect for the cave.”

So maybe this is not new.

But it still needs correcting.

Not with rage. Not with some dramatic family summit where I stand at a podium and unveil the Household Boundary Restoration Act of 2026, complete with snack enforcement provisions and guitar handling amendments. Although, to be honest, there are days when that sounds super happy.

It probably starts smaller than that.

Knock first.

Ask first.

If it is not yours, do not use it without permission.

If the door is closed, there is a reason.

If you want the snack, ask. If you want the guitar, ask. If you want to explore the stereo, ask, and prepare yourself for a lecture about knobs, balance, receiver settings, and the golden age of audio equipment that you absolutely did not request.

That is not too much.

It is not anti-kid. It is not harsh. It is not some cranky old man defense of private property because I once watched a Clint Eastwood movie and got ideas. It is the basic training of living with other human beings.

I want my boys to feel at home. I also want them to know that home is where we learn how to treat people, not where we practice ignoring them.

There is room for grace in all of this. Kids are impulsive. Teenage boys especially seem to operate with a brain that is still downloading the update for “consider other people.” I know they are not sneaking snacks because they are making a philosophical statement about ownership. They are hungry. They are bored. They are curious. They are boys, which means some portion of their decision-making process is basically a raccoon wearing gym shorts.

I get it.

But I also know that if I do not teach the line, the world will. And the world is usually less patient than a dad standing in the hallway holding an empty snack box and wondering where he went wrong.

So maybe the answer is not to bring back fear.

Maybe the answer is to bring back permission.

Not permission as control. Permission as respect. Permission as a small pause before taking. Permission as the ordinary courtesy of remembering that the people closest to you are still people.

That feels like a decent place to start.